



COLLISION On June 17, a goods train collided with Kanchanjunga Express in West Bengal, killing 10 and injuring many

Sudhanshu Mani, former General Manager of rail coach manufacturer, Integral Coach Factory, Chennai, says there is no time to play the blame game.

“The Kanchenjunga Express accident underscores the need for a much faster rollout of Kavach, which would have surely prevented this tragedy. It is disappointing that Indian Railways is trying to get away with excuses like industry capacity (for Kavach production),” he says.

The vacant positions in engineering, loco pilot, and safety-related departments in Indian Railways have also been flagged by experts as an area that requires urgent attention.

“There has been a steep fall in the induction of engineers in the Railways in the last few years and that is now being reflected in the opera-

tional side of the Railways. Implementation of Kavach and some other infra projects have been delayed and need to be fixed,” says Lalit Chandra Trivedi, former Indian Railways General Manager.

Responding to an RTI query filed by Chandra Shekhar Gaur, a Madhya Pradesh-based RTI Act activist, Railways said that about 270,000 posts were lying vacant as of June 2023 with more than 170,000 in the safety category. Railway trade unions have regularly raised the issue of rising stress on officials and workers in the safety category due to a shortage of personnel.

The first field trials of Kavach on passenger trains were started in February 2016. Based on experience gained and the Independent Safety Assessment, three firms—HBL

Power Systems, Kernex Microsystems, and Medha Servo Drives—were approved in 2018-19, for the supply of Kavach. Subsequently, Kavach was adopted as a National ATP system in July 2020.

Efforts are being made to develop more original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) to enhance the capacity and to scale up the implementation of Kavach. New OEMs are expected to be taken on board for the upcoming tenders.

The plan is to deploy the system on the entire railway route to enhance safety for the transport system, which gets 23 million passengers every day. The allocation for Kavach could be enhanced in the upcoming Budget. **BT**

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